IGCSE Drama Glossary

Drama Vocabulary	Definition
Acting area	The area within the performance space within which the actor may move in full view of the audience. Also known as the playing area.
Acting Style	A particular manner of acting which reflects cultural and historical influences.
Action	The movement or development of the plot or story in a play; the sense of forward movement created by the sense of time and/or the physical and psychological motivations of characters.
Analysis	In responding to dramatic art, the process of examining how the elements of drama – literary, technical, and performance – are used.
Antagonist	The opponent or adversary of the hero or main character of a drama; one who opposes and actively competes with another character in a play, most often with the protagonist.
Apron	The area between the front curtain and the edge of the stage.
Arena stage	Type of stage without a frame or arch separating the stage from the auditorium, in which the audience surrounds the stage area.
Articulation	The clarity or distinction of speech.
Aside	Lines spoken by an actor to the audience and not supposed to be overheard by other characters on stage.
Back projection	A method of projecting images onto a translucent screen from behind. Often used for projected scenery or special effects. Because the projector is usually close to the screen, special lenses are needed to ensure that the image seen by the audience is large enough.
Backdrop	A flat surface the width of the stage, hung upstage of the acting area, upon which scenery is usually painted.
Backlight	Light coming from upstage, behind scenery or actors, to sculpt and separate them from the background.
Barn doors	A rotatable attachment consisting of two or four metal flaps (hinged) which is fixed to the front of a Fresnel spotlight to cut off the beam in a particular direction(s).
Battens	Compartmentalised floodlights set up so as to allow colour mixing. Low voltage battens are commonly used as light curtains and for colour washes. Known in the US as a strip light.
Bifocal spot	Profile lantern with two sets of shutters, one of which produces a hard edge, and one a soft edge.
Black box	A one-room theatre, without a proscenium arch; interior is painted black, including walls, floor, and ceiling, and any drapes are also black.
Blackout	A lighting cue where all stage lights go off simultaneously.

Blocking	The path formed by the actor's movement on stage, usually determined by the director with assistance from the actor, and often written down in a script using commonly accepted theatrical symbols.
Box set	A set with three walls and a ceiling, leaving the fourth wall to be imagined by the actors. The box set represents a real room with doors and windows that work.
Business	A piece of unscripted or improvised action, often comic in intention, used to establish a character, fill a pause in dialogue, or to establish a scene. An author may simply suggest 'business' to indicate the need for some action at that point in the play.
Catharsis	A theory advocated by Aristotle in his Poetics which attempts to describe thefeeling of release felt by the audience at the end of a tragedy; the audienceexperiences catharsis, or is set free from the emotional hold of the action, afterexperiencing strong emotions and sharing in the protagonist's troubles.
Character	A person portrayed in a drama, novel, or other artistic piece.
Characterisation	How an actor uses body, voice, and thought to develop and portray a character.
Choreography	The movement of actors and dancers to music in a play.
Chorus	A group of performers who sing, dance, or recite in unison; in Greek drama, the chorus was the group of performers who sang and danced between episodes, narrated off-stage action, and commented on events.
Climax	The point of greatest intensity in a series or progression of events in a play, often forming the turning point of the plot and leading to some kind of resolution.
Cloth	A piece of scenic canvas, painted or plain that is flown or fixed to hang in a vertical position. A backcloth (or backdrop) hangs at the rear of a scene. A floor cloth is a painted canvas sheet placed on the stage floor to mark out the acting area, or to achieve a particular effect. A front cloth hangs well downstage, often to hide a scene change taking place behind.
Colour filter	A sheet of plastic usually composed of a coloured resin sandwiched between two clear pieces. The coloured filter absorbs all the colours of light except the colour of the filter itself, which it allows through. A colour filter is sometimes known as a 'gel', after 'gelatine', from which filters were originally made.
Colour mixing	Combining the effects of two or more lighting gels.

Comedy	A play that treats characters and situations in a humorous way. Low comedy is physical rather than intellectual comedy; high comedy is more sophisticated, emphasizing verbal with more than physical action.
Comic relief	A break in the tension of a tragedy provided by a comic character, a comic episode, or even a comic line.
Concentration	The actor's focus, also called centering; focusing on the work at hand, being in character, or being in the moment.
Conflict	The internal or external struggle between opposing forces, ideas, or interests that creates dramatic tension.
Contrast	Dynamic use of opposites, such as movement/stillness, sound/silence, and light/ darkness.
Cross fade	Bringing another lighting state up to completely replace the current lighting state. Also applies to sound effects/music. Sometimes abbreviated to Xfade or XF.
Cyclorama	A fabric drop hung from a curved or segmented batten, or a curved wall at the back of the stage, upon which light can be cast to create effects (cyc for short).
Denouement	The moment in a drama when the essential plot point is unraveled or explained.
Development	Progression of the plot or conflict in a play.
Dialogue	Spoken conversation used by two or more characters to express thoughts, feelings, and actions.
Downlight	A light from directly above the acting area.
Dynamic	The energetic range of, or variations within physical movement or the difference between levels of sound.
End on	Traditional audience seating layout where the audience is looking at the stage from the same direction. This seating layout is that of a proscenium arch theatre.
Ensemble	The dynamic interaction and harmonious blending of the efforts of the many artists involved in the dramatic activity of theatrical production.
Exposition	The part of a play that introduces the theme, chief characters, and current circumstances.
Farce	An extreme form of comedy that depends on quick tempo and flawless timing and is characterised by improbable events and farfetched coincidences; from the French meaning 'to stuff'.
Flashback	In a non-linear plot, to go back in time to a previous event; a flash forward would move the action into the future.
Flat	A wooden frame, usually covered with painted cloth, used to create walls or separations on stage.
Flood	To wash the stage with general lighting. The name given to a basic box-

	shaped lantern with a simple reflector used to achieve this effect.
Focus	In lighting, the adjustment of the size and shape of a stage light and/or the direction in which it is aimed; in acting, the act of concentrating or staying in character.
Fourth wall	The invisible wall of a set through which the audience sees the action of the play.
Fresnel spotlight	Adjustable spotlight giving a diffused light, created by the construction of its lens of 'concentric circles'. Used with Barn doors.
Genre	A category of literary or dramatic composition; drama is a literary genre. Drama is further divided into tragedy, comedy, farce, and melodrama, and these genres, in turn, can be subdivided.
Gesture	Any movement of the actor's head, shoulder, arm, hand, leg, or foot to convey meaning.
Groundrow	Compartmentalised floodlights set up on the stage floor so as to allow colour mixing. Commonly used to light curtains and for colour washes. See also Batten.
Hand props	Properties such as tools, weapons, or luggage that are carried on stage by an individual actor. See also Personal props, Props.
House lights	The lights that illuminate the auditorium before and after the performance and during intermission.
Imaging	A technique which allows performers to slow down and focus individually on an issue. The performers, sitting quietly with eyes closed, allow pictures to form in their minds. These images may be motivated by bits of narration, music, sounds, smells, etc.
Improvisation	The spontaneous use of movement and speech to create a character or object in a particular situation; acting done without a script.
Inflection	Change in pitch or loudness of the voice.
Interaction	The action or relationship among two or more characters.
Irony	An implied discrepancy between what is said and what is meant. There areseveral forms of irony. Verbal irony is when a writer or speaker says one thingand means something else (often the opposite of what is said). When theaudience perceives something that a character does not know, that is dramaticirony. Situational irony can be described as a discrepancy between expectedresults and the actual results.
Isolation	Control of isolated body parts; the ability to control or move one part of the body independently of the rest.
Kinesthetic	Resulting from the sensation of bodily position, presence, or movement.
Language	In drama, the particular manner of verbal expression, the diction or style of writing, or the speech or phrasing that suggests a class or profession or type of character.

Lantern	The generic term for a stage spotlight.
Light set	A term used to describe a situation where no physical set is used on stage. The 'set' is created entirely by means of lighting.
Mannerism	A peculiarity of speech or behaviour.
Melodrama	A style of play, which originated in the 19th century, relying heavily on sensationalism and sentimentality. Melodramas tend to feature action more than motivation, stock characters, and a strict view of morality in which good triumphs over evil.
Mime	Acting without words.
Mirroring	Copying the movement and/or expression or look of someone else exactly.
Monologue	A long speech made by one actor; a monologue may be delivered alone or in the presence of others.
Mood	The tone or feeling of the play, often engendered by the music, setting, or lighting.
Motivation	The reason or reasons for a character's behaviour; an incentive or inducement for further action for a character.
Movement	Stage blocking or the movements of the actors onstage during performance; also refers to the action of the play as it moves from event to event.
Naturalism	A style of drama that developed in the late 19th century as an attempt to represent real life on stage faithfully and without artifice; the actions of characters tend to be dominated by determinism (societal or environmental forces).
Pace	Rate of movement or speed of action.
Parody	A mocking or satirical imitation of a literary or dramatic work.
Performance elements	Includes acting (e.g. character motivation and analysis, empathy), speaking (breath control, vocal expression and inflection, projection, speaking style, diction), and non-verbal expression (gestures, body alignment, facial expression, character blocking, movement).
Personal props	Small props that are usually carried in an actor's costume, such as money or a pen. See also Hand props, Props.
Pitch	The particular level of a voice, instrument or tune.
Plot	The events of a play or arrangement of action, as opposed to the theme. See also Story line.
Plot development	The organisation or building of the action in a play.
Posture	Physical alignment of a performer's body, or a physical stance taken by aperformer which conveys information about the character being played.
Profile lantern	A focusable spotlight having an ellipsoidal lens which enables a sharp-

	edged beam of light to be projected.
Prompt	To give actors their lines as a reminder; the prompter is the one who assists actors in remembering their lines.
Props	Short for properties; any article, except costume or scenery, used as part of a dramatic production; any moveable object that appears on stage during a performance. See also Hand props, Personal props.
Proscenium	A frame or arch separating the stage from the auditorium. The proscenium opening was of particular importance to the Realistic playwrights of the 19th century, such as Ibsen and Shaw, for whom it was a picture frame or an imaginary fourth wall through which the audience experienced the illusion of spying on characters.
Protagonist	The main character or hero in a play or other literary work.
Proxemics	Contemporary term for 'spatial relationships' referring to spatial signifiers of the relationship between different performers or a performer and elements of the set which convey information about character and circumstances.
Realism	An attempt to represent everyday life and people as they are character motivation, costume, setting, and dialogue. Plays from this period (from 1820 to 1920) seek the truth, find beauty in the commonplace, and focus on the conditions of the working class.
Resolution	How the problem or conflict in a drama is solved or concluded.
Rhythm	Measured flow of words or phrases in verse forming patterns of sound. Regularity in time or space of an action, process or feature.
Ritual	A prescribed form or ceremony; drama grew out of religious ritual.
Role	The character portrayed by an actor in a drama.
Role playing	Improvising movement and dialogue to put oneself in another's place in a particular situation, often to examine the person(s) and/or situation(s) being improvised.
Satire	A play in which sarcasm, irony, and ridicule are used to expose or attack folly or pretension in society.
Scene	A small section or portion of a play.
Scenery	The theatrical equipment, such as curtains, flats, backdrops, or platforms, used in a dramatic production to communicate environment.
Scenography	The art of creating performance environments using one or more components including light, costume, set, space and sound.
Scrim	A drop made of fabric that seems almost opaque when lit from the front but semitransparent when lit from behind.
Set	The physical surroundings, visible to the audience, in which the action of the play takes place.

Set designer	The person who designs the physical surroundings in which the action of the play takes place.
Setting	When and where the action of a play takes place.
Sightlines	Imaginary lines of sight that determine what areas of the stage are visible to the audience from any given seat in the house.
Soliloquy	A speech in which an actor, usually alone on stage, speaks the inner thoughts of his/her character aloud.
Sound	The effects an audience hears during a performance to communicate character, context, or environment.
Sound effects	Recorded: often abbreviated to FX. There are many sources for recorded sound effects, from CDs, to downloading from the internet. May form an obvious part of the action (train arriving at station) or may be in the background throughout a scene (e.g. birds chirping). Live: gunshots, door slams, and offstage voices (amongst many others) are most effective when done live.
Sound elements	Music, sound effects, actors' voices.
Space	A defined area.
Spatial relationships	(Or spatial awareness). Traditional term for what is currently referred to as proxemics, referring to spatial signifiers of the relationship between different performers or a performer and elements of the set which convey information about character and circumstances.
Special effects	Visual or sound effects used to enhance a theatrical performance.
Stage presence	The level of comfort, commitment, and energy an actor appears to have on stage.
Staging	Another term for blocking; deliberate choices about where the actors stand and how they move on stage to communicate character relationships and plot and to create interesting stage pictures.
Stock characters	Characters who represent particular personality types or characteristics of human behaviour. Stock characters are immediately recognisable and appear throughout the history of theatre, beginning with Greek and Roman comedy and elaborated upon in Commedia dell' Arte.
Storyline	The plot or plan of action.
Structure	The arrangement of and relationship between the constituent parts of a whole as in 'prologue, exposition, dénouement' or scenes and acts within a play.
Stylisation	The shaping of dramatic material, settings, or costumes in a deliberately nonrealistic manner.
Suspense	A feeling of uncertainty as to the outcome, used to build interest and excitement on the part of the audience.
Symbolism	The use of symbolic language, imagery, or colour to evoke emotions or

	ideas.
Tableau	A technique in creative drama in which actors create a frozen picture, as if the action were paused; plural is tableaux. Not to be confused with freeze frame, which is a term used in film and video production and which should not be used when discussing drama.
Tempo	Relative speed or rate of movement in pace over time, e.g. the speed at which the music for a dance should be played. Can be applied to dramatic contexts such as in 'tempo rhythm'.
Tension	The atmosphere created by unresolved, disquieting, or inharmonious situations that human beings feel compelled to address; the state of anxiety the audience feels because of a threat to a character in a play.
Text	The basis of dramatic activity and performance; a written script or an agreed upon structure and content for an improvisation.
Theatre games	Improvisational exercises structured by the director or teacher to achieve a specific objective, such as breaking down inhibitions or establishing trust.
Theatre-in-the-round	An acting area or stage that may be viewed from all sides simultaneously.
Theme	The basic idea of a play; the idea, point of view, or perception that binds together a work of art.
Thrust	A stage that extends into the audience area, with seats on three sides of a peninsula-shaped acting space.
Timbre	The distinctive character or quality of a musical or vocal sound apart from its pitch or intensity such as in a nasal voice quality.
Timing	Includes setting cues for effects and lighting, synchronising two or more things that must happen simultaneously, and establishing the pace at which lines will be delivered or the play performed.
Traverse	Form of staging where the audience is on either side of the acting area.
Turning point	The climax or high point of a story, when events can go either way.
Upstage (verb)	To deliberately draw the audience's attention away from another actor or actors by overacting, using flashy bits of business, or other means.
Vocal expression	How an actor uses his or her voice to convey character.
Vocal projection	Directing the voice out of the body to be heard clearly at a distance.
Voice	The combination of vocal qualities an actor uses such as articulation, phrasing, and pronunciation.
Wings	Offstage areas to the right and left of the acting/onstage area.